

Tibetan leaders signing the Seventeen-Point Agreement

In 1954, Mao Tse-tung invited the Dalai Lama to China. During the almost yearlong visit, Mao and the Dalai Lama had public and private meetings. The Dalai Lama was polite and willing to listen. He was impressed by some of the things Mao had done to help modernize China. But he also saw the poor living conditions of the people in China's countryside. Near the end of the trip, Mao said, "Religion is poison." This scared the Dalai Lama. The Buddhist religion was the center of Tibetan culture.